

both sides in an attempt to win the field, but by the end of the day neither side had gained the advantage.

That night Thomas ordered his men to dig entrenchments, while Rosecrans reinforced him. Meanwhile, the majority of Longstreet's two divisions joined Bragg's army. Bragg decided to renew the fight the next day with an army-wide attack *en echelon*, in a slightly staggered right-to-left sequence. Leonidas Polk's wing was to start the action on the right, which would progress to Longstreet, who controlled the left.

On the morning of September 20, Polk's divisions—which had started late—battered against Thomas's entrenched defenders to no avail. Bragg became frustrated with Polk and canceled the echelon attack, and ordered Longstreet to assault with everything he had. Unbeknownst to either Bragg or Rosecrans, Longstreet had prepared his troops for such an event. Perhaps remembering Pickett's Charge, where linear formations had failed to pierce the enemy line, he had arranged his brigades in columns.

When Longstreet ordered the attack at about 11:30 a.m., it hit the enemy with tremendous power and, unfortunately for Rosecrans, precisely in a location that one of his divisions had just mistakenly vacated. Poor staff work was responsible for an error that now left a quarter-mile (402-m) gap in the Union lines, and as Longstreet's veterans poured through, they demolished the Federal right and sent one-third of Rosecrans's army running for their lives to Chattanooga. The Union commander joined the flight, abandoning his army to its fate.

Longstreet now smelled a victory of strategic proportions and ordered in his last reserves, at the same time begging Bragg to send him reinforcements. When none materialized, a nonplussed Longstreet pressed forward nonetheless, only to come up against Thomas's corps. The Union general had ordered them to make a rearguard stand on Horseshoe Ridge, in a bid to protect the retreat of the rest of the army. Longstreet responded by throwing assault after assault, but each time Thomas held firm, his valor and steadfast conduct later earning him the nickname "The Rock of Chickamauga."